

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, September 26, 2018, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

At-Large Councilor Claire Lessard
Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Jeremy Zullo
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope

Also present:

Ryan McNutt, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

Per Mayor Lovett:

- Sullivan County Commissioners Update moved to later meeting
- Ordinance 562 moved to October 10th meeting
- Non-Public session will come after Consultation with Legal Counsel

Council concurred.

MAYOR’S NOTES

Mayor Lovett’s notes:

- Attended NH’s First Work-Based Learning Excellence Awards on September 25th where Scott Pope received an award.
- Greendot is hosting a program, Going for the Gold, featuring Olympic Gold Medalist “Merciless” Ray Mercer, September 28, 6:30 p.m., Stevens High School.
- September 19 the Policy Committee met. There was no quorum. There was a discussion regarding the establishment of a Board of Assessors. Each Committee member has been assigned one of four cities (Berlin, Concord, Keene, Lebanon) to research how their Board of Assessors operates.

Mr. Damren noticed a Facebook posting from Sherry Johnston thanking Police Officer Michael Puksta for being kind and helpful during a not-so-good situation.

Mr. McNutt said there will be a Racial Healing Working Group meeting tomorrow at REMIX, 6:30 p.m. Public is encouraged to attend.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Policy Committee

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Pope to appoint Charlene Lovett to the Policy Committee.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

Gary Dickerman, Ward 2 resident and Chairman of the Conservation Commission, said there will be a Source to Sea Cleanup on Friday and Saturday. It will encompass the entire river watershed. Eversource will send 20 volunteers on Friday. The Commission and other volunteers will meet on Saturday at the Visitors Center. A few sites that need attention are: below the Visitors Center; Sullivan and Twistback Road; Lower Main Street; Jarvis Hill; Red Water Brook Road; and Ashley Ferry Landing. Mr. McNutt said Half Mile Road also needs cleanup.

OLD BUSINESS

Discussion of Adoption of RSA 72:61-72

RSA 72:61-64 Solar Energy Systems Exemption; RSA 72:65-68 Wind-Powered Energy Systems Exemption; and RSA 72:69-72 Woodheating Energy Systems Exemptions.

Mayor Lovett said one of the Objectives in the Master Plan is to Adopt RSA 72:61-72, which will permit the City to offer a property tax exemption for small-scale renewable energy generation projects, such as solar panels and small wind-powered energy systems.

Joe Lessard, Interim Assessor, said that he has not seen an increase in market value due to the installation of renewable energy systems in NH and Maine.

Mr. Damren noted that the life expectancy of solar panels would probably exceed the life expectancy of a building's roof, so they may need to be taken down and reinstalled when the roof is replaced.

Mayor Lovett said the overall purpose for the tax exemptions is to be tax neutral.

Mr. Lessard said he understands the creation of the exemptions would be to promote the use of renewable energy sources. There is no data, yet, in terms of market value. Currently, exemptions are neutral. The assessment doesn't increase because you've added it and there is no reduction in the current assessment.

Mr. Lessard talked about unintended consequences and said that if the cost is deducted from assessed value then there would be a loss in total assessed value of the community.

Mayor Lovett said the idea is to give property owners the potential to increase market value of their properties while producing their own energy.

Regarding valuing the system, Mr. Lessard said you would have to analyze the market.

Councilors asked for a draft ordinance to be brought forward and to have it include solar electric, solar hot water, wind energy and wood heating.

Mr. Koloski said he has been through some fire training regarding solar installations and the panels are live all the time. He would like to have input from the Planning and Development Department on this.

Mayor Lovett asked if this could come back to the Council on October 24. Mr. McNutt said he will work on that.

NEW BUSINESS

Sullivan County Commissioners Update

Moved to future meeting.

Request to Dedicate New Airport Community Hangar to Roger Hamel – Public Hearing

Proposed wording for the bronze plaque: The Roger A. Hamel Community Hangar 2018.

Joe Osgood, Ward 2 resident and Airport Advisory Committee member, said that Roger Hamel works behind the scenes at the airport and he gets things done. He has been at the airport for a great number of years. Mr. Osgood said Mr. Hamel doesn't care to be recognized, but Mr. Osgood believes Mr. Hamel's name should be on the Community Hangar. Mayor Lovett asked if Mr. Hamel is a World War II veteran. Mr. Osgood said yes.

Mayor Lovett read a letter of support from Ed Farris, President, Matrix Aerospace Corporation.

Bryan Burr, Fire Chief and Airport Manager, said that Mr. Hamel is 92 years old today. Chief Burr read his letter of support and strongly recommended the Council move forward with the dedication of the hangar to Mr. Hamel. The plaque is estimated to cost \$200-\$300 and there has been an offer to pay for it.

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Ms. Kier to dedicate the new Airport Community Hangar to Roger Hamel.

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing.

Dave Carton, Ward 2, said he had also written a letter of support for this dedication. He has known Mr. Hamel for almost 50 years. Mr. Hamel is an ambassador for the City.

Mayor Lovett closed the public hearing.

Voice vote: 9-0.

Ordinance 562 – Amending the Non-Union Employee Classification Plan – First Reading

Moved to October 10, 2018, meeting.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Mr. Koloski would like to discuss reviewing the Elderly tax exemption sooner rather than later. Mayor Lovett said to put on the October 24 agenda, Review of the Elderly Exemption and Veterans' Tax Credit.

Mayor Lovett asked Mr. McNutt to do a public forum regarding Topstone sooner rather than later.

Mayor Lovett said the Policy Committee needs to meet two times a month, the first and third Thursday of the month. The next meeting will be October 4th.

Mayor Lovett said to add a standing item on the Council agenda, Assessment Abatement Process Update.

Mayor Lovett said on October 24 she would like to start the process of examining the City Charter in regard to the assessment abatement process. She said there are gray areas and oddities that need to be looked at.

Mr. Damren said he would like to have the Fire Department Fee Schedule changes on the October 10 agenda.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

NON-PUBLIC SESSION PURSUANT TO RSA 91-A:3,II(a) – PERSONNEL

7:19 A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. O'Hearne to enter the Non-Public session pursuant to RSA 91-A:3,II(a) – Personnel and to invite Mr. McNutt into the session.

Roll call vote:

Lessard - yes
O'Hearne - yes
Stone - yes
Damren - yes
Zullo - yes
Kier - yes
Koloski - yes
Pope - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. O'Hearne to exit the Non-Public session.

Roll call vote:

Lessard - yes
O'Hearne - yes
Stone - yes
Damren - yes
Zullo - yes
Kier - yes
Koloski - yes
Pope - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Kier to seal the minutes because it is determined that divulgence of this information likely would affect adversely the reputation of any person other than a member of this board; such minutes to remain sealed unless and until the purpose for which the information discussed has been requested to be sealed no longer applies.

Roll call vote:

Lessard - yes
O'Hearne - yes
Stone - yes
Damren - yes
Zullo - yes
Kier - yes
Koloski - no
Pope - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 8-1.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Zullo to authorize the Mayor to contact legal counsel.

Roll call vote:

Lessard - yes

O'Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Damren - yes

Zullo - yes

Kier - yes

Koloski - yes

Pope - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

ADJOURNMENT

At 9:06 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Zullo to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council